



MONTHLY UPDATE

Namibia: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-03 • 41 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • DIGITALISATION • TECHNOLOGY • CAPACITY • INCLUSION • DATA • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The electronic identity card acquired a shape and a price. The ministry [set out ten-year card validity and PIN authentication](#) and [clarified the fee schedule, duplicates included](#), while the Data Protection Bill [is still in finalisation and has not been tabled](#) – an identity card arriving ahead of the law that would govern what is done with it.

Two artificial-intelligence contracts went opposite ways in the same month: an agricultural monitoring contract [was reported let for a year](#), and a crop-monitoring contract [was discontinued with the ministry weighing action against the authorising official](#). Elsewhere China [handed over the country's first satellite data-receiving ground station](#), operators [were instructed to retire 2G and 3G and reform the spectrum](#), and the central bank [put full functionality of the instant payment solution at about June 2027](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The ICT minister met a consultancy delegation in Windhoek on 3 August on trustworthy artificial intelligence, broadband access, cybersecurity, data centres, clean energy and women in technology, and stated that consultations on the strategy framework had already begun under the research council and that government has prioritised a strategy before introducing legislation ([ministerial account](#)). No contract, terms of reference or procurement route involving the consultancy is established ([second account](#)).

Legislation and regulation

The Data Protection Bill has not moved. It [is still in finalisation and has not been tabled](#), against the September introduction the ministry had named. The bill has been described as being finalised across successive periods, and the electronic identity rollout it would govern begins in that same month.

Data protection

Namibia said no to a data deal. The government [rejected a United States health data and specimen-sharing proposal, citing sovereignty](#), while the two sides [raced to finalise HIV funding talks with the data-sharing question still open](#). A refusal of this kind is rare enough on this base to be worth recording as its own position. What the record held does not carry is the text of what was proposed, or what the funding now depends on.

Regional collaboration

The memorandum with Botswana was signed. The two ICT ministries [signed at Kasane on 7 August, covering digital transformation, cybersecurity, connectivity and skills development](#), and published detail with it: [the Trans-Kalahari Corridor's remaining 4G gaps costed at about N\\$52 million across 13 new sites, and the Gobabis-Buitepos fibre link completed and interconnecting with the Botswana backbone company at Charles Hill](#), the first direct cross-border fibre link between the two operators. The signed instrument itself is not held.

Four lighter engagements ran alongside. Cabinet approved a memorandum on information technology cooperation with [the Republic of Congo, authorising the minister to sign without publishing scope, financing or a signature date](#). Namibia joined four other governments as a founding partner of [a pan-African African-language artificial-intelligence initiative launched at Abuja on 24 July](#), committing ministerial support rather than a named contribution. The fourth joint trade committee in New Delhi on 12 August [advanced cybersecurity and digital-economy cooperation with India](#). The regional regulators' association [opened its legal and policy committee at Windhoek from 10 to 12 August, on artificial-intelligence governance, data governance, digital public infrastructure and regulatory harmonisation](#), and the communications regulator [signed a five-year memorandum with the electricity distributor at Ondangwa on information and data sharing and rural electrification](#). None of the five publishes a work programme, term or timetable.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The dominant mobile operator [publicly rejected customer claims that it takes data](#), its data adviser telling a trade-fair discussion on 30 August 2026 that billing is consumption-based, attributing rapid depletion to video streaming and hotspot sharing, and distinguishing consumption from bundle expiry. The operator said it is building a control letting customers opt in or out of airtime being spent on data once a bundle runs out; no implementation date was given. It is the one argument in this section held with a company rather than a ministry, and the only one that produced a stated product change.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Spectrum is being taken back rather than added. Operators [were instructed to retire their 2G and 3G networks and reform the spectrum, with one suggesting smartphone subsidies before the shutdown](#). A shutdown without a device programme moves the cost of the transition onto the users least able to carry it, and no date, subsidy or handset count is on the record.

The largest mobile operator said it [will put N\\$624.9 million into telecommunications infrastructure in the 2025/26 financial year](#) – a stated commitment rather than a delivered figure.

Data Storage

The national data centre moved from a Cabinet directive to a budget line: it is now [one of the ICT ministry's flagship projects for 2026/27 inside a N\\$639.2 million budget](#). Four years after a government task force found the country had none and recommended building one, it still has no site, capacity, cost or completion date.

Cybersecurity

The trust layer beneath the September electronic identity launch was signed in the last week of the month. The communications regulator and a German identity vendor [signed an implementation agreement with the home affairs ministry connecting it to the regulator's national trust framework](#), with the regulator as national root certification

authority and the ministry becoming the first certification service provider through the issue of electronic identity documents. It is the first named certification service provider on this ledger, and it arrives a fortnight before the credential it is meant to certify.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

The identity ministry reported on 23 July that it printed 166,237 identity documents between 1 April 2025 and 30 June 2026 of which 125,999 were collected, leaving 40,238 uncollected, and that a school registration drive had reached 24 of 55 target schools ([ministry figures](#)).

The regional outreach opened in Omaheke on 27 July and ran to 5 August across all seven constituencies, delivered with a development agency and the regulator ([outreach account](#)). The regional governor said marginalised communities need to be convinced to take up the card, and the ministry team named low literacy as the obstacle to understanding it ([governor's account](#)).

Alongside the outreach runs a [Youth e-ID Ambassadors Programme](#), using young people to promote take-up of the [credential and civic participation](#). Participant numbers, cost, duration and any effect on enrolment are unstated, and the funding agency's own account is the only one the base holds.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The central bank, the instant payments company and the clearing house signed a declaration of intent on 2 July to integrate instant payments with the national clearing infrastructure, publishing no deliverables, funding or timetable ([declaration account](#)).

The payments association's annual general meeting on 28 July also heard that licensing and supervision of payment providers will move to the central bank, with no instrument, commencement date or transition plan published ([central bank account](#)).

The central bank governor put a date on the phone-based channel. He [said on 27 August that a digital money and instant payment solution should be fully functional by about June 2027, sequenced government-to-person, then person-to-person and person-to-merchant](#), pitching it as a way to build transaction histories that substitute for the financial statements banks demand of informal businesses. How cash integrates was not stated.

Registries

The business and intellectual property authority [offers online name search, name reservation and application-status verification](#), with no transaction or uptake figure published and no publication date on the capture. The civil registration statute is unchanged and was [read by officials on 25 July as permitting institutions to accept either the physical card or its digital version, with disclosure conditional on the holder's consent](#). Its [commencement date is not established](#) and the held record summarises rather than reproduces it.

The securities depository was used for the first time by a listed corporate issuer. A N\$250.5 million sustainability-linked bond [was converted into an electronic record on 21 August after bondholders were notified on 8 August, the first practical use of the depository since the exchange launched it in December 2025](#); the issuer's three other listed bonds were notified for 8 September.

Sectoral management information systems

The Roads Authority [commissioned a N\\$13 million project control system](#) to strengthen oversight of road projects. No project count, user base or reporting output accompanies it.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Windhoek's council [adopted a ten-year smart-city strategy on 15 June, handed over with UN-Habitat and a United Nations cities accelerator](#). The named projects are commercialisation of the city's own fibre network as a digital backbone and a proposed commuter rail linking Windhoek, Katutura and Rehoboth. No funding requirement, implementation timetable or institutional owner is published, and the [Chinese contribution to the pilot drew a parliamentary question about who controls the data](#).

Technology

AI

The month's artificial-intelligence work is language work. The development programme's account of 13 August records [an indigenous-language voice-data repository being built through its AI sprint with the national science and technology university](#). No language count, corpus size, licence or release date is stated, and the question a speech corpus raises above all others — who owns the recorded voices, and on what terms they may train a model — is not addressed in the account.

The state's own first artificial-intelligence contract asks the same question of a different dataset, and answers part of it. A [one-year contract with a United States firm at N\\$39.5m, about US\\$2.4m, introduces satellite imagery, remote sensing and artificial-intelligence monitoring of mahangu, maize, sorghum, cowpea and wheat](#); the agriculture ministry says Namibia retains ownership of the satellite and crop data generated and will receive model and skills transfer. The award drew public objection over transparency and local participation, and no procurement route, tender record or text of the data-ownership and transfer terms is published.

Innovation ecosystem

Two small pieces of ecosystem plumbing. The ninth national ICT summit [received over N\\$1.2 million ahead of the event](#), and the communications regulator [held a second entrepreneurship breakfast in Oshakati to build the northern digital economy](#). Both are convening rather than capital: nothing in the record held names a company founded, funded or scaled through either.

Capacity

Training and skills

A private provider [opened an artificial-intelligence academy in Windhoek](#) for Namibian organisations. It is a commercial offering rather than a public programme, which is what the base otherwise holds nothing of here; no intake, curriculum or fee structure is published.

Inclusion

Access to services

The central bank's deputy governor told the payments association's annual general meeting on 28 July that financial inclusion rose from 78% in 2017 to 86% in 2025, and named continued cash reliance, limited rural access, informal-sector barriers and the digital divide as the persistent constraints ([central bank account](#)).

Education added a channel built for the same margins. The education ministry and UNICEF [launched a Namibia Learning Passport, a digital and offline learning platform aimed at rural, remote and underserved young people](#), at the international youth day event in Keetmanshoop. No user target, content catalogue, device requirement or offline distribution route is stated, which matters most for the audience the platform names.

What that looks like in one region was put to the parliamentary ICT committee on 11 August: [21 of Kavango West's 188 schools have workable connectivity, leaving 55,002 learners without digital teaching tools](#), and health officials told the same committee that clinics there still struggle with unreliable mobile coverage. The figures are the regional education director's own, and they sit against a target of full telecommunications coverage by 2030.

Data

National statistics

The statistics agency is publishing both its data and, unusually, an account of its own machinery. Its [data portals and microdata catalogue are live, neither page carrying its own publication date](#); the [second-quarter producer price index bulletin is held in full](#); and the agency [disclosed in that bulletin that it has completed a migration of the index's compilation system](#). Disclosing a system change inside the statistical release it affects is the practice that lets a reader judge a break in series; no back-series revision or comparability note is published with it.

Open data

The environment ministry put a data platform where the country has no open-data policy at all. Its [Multilateral Environmental Agreements monitoring and reporting platform launched at N\\$12m in the week of 7 August](#), built with UNDP under a Global Environment Facility land-governance project to centralise environmental data for national reporting. No public access, dataset list, licence or publication rule is stated, so on the record held it is a reporting tool rather than open data — and the access-to-information statute that would give a citizen a claim on any of it remains enacted and uncommenced.

A second dataset arrived from outside government altogether. A privately built application [launched nationwide on 14 August taking public reports of more than thirty kinds of infrastructure and service-delivery fault onto a mapped national dataset, with automatic facial and licence-plate redaction](#). It is privately held: no user count, arrangement with any authority, or licence for the data is stated, which is the difference between a dataset and an open one.

Use of satellite data

China [handed over a satellite data-receiving ground station at the earth station outside Windhoek, Namibia's first, receiving remote-sensing data and operated by fourteen trained Namibians](#). The handover date is inferred from a weekday named in a report published the next day, and no operating agreement, data-sharing term or ownership arrangement is held.

Geopolitics

India activities

A five-node high-performance computing cluster is specified for deployment at the science and technology university in Windhoek — 17.7 TF peak, 5,320 cores, 480 GB memory and 100 TB of storage under the India-Namibia centre of excellence. No operator, cost or opening date is published. It is a university research cluster, not the national high-performance computing facility the gaps register still seeks.

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